

HongSeok Kim

Updated May 30, 2026

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Citizenship: Republic of Korea (F1)

Education

Iowa State University

Ph.D. in Economics

Advisor: Professor Juan Carlos Córdoba.

Ames, IA USA

2021 –

Hanyang University

M.A. in Economics and Finance

B.A. in Economics and Finance

Seoul, Republic of Korea

2021

2019

Research Interests

Macroeconomics, Labor economics, Economics of Aging

Job Market Paper

[2] **Precautionary Retirement: Social Security Solvency Risk, Claiming, and Work**

Abstract. Social Security insures households against old-age income risk. But when Social Security itself becomes fiscally risky, households must insure against the insurer. I study how perceived solvency risk changes retirement behavior before any reform is enacted. I build a life-cycle model in which older households jointly choose saving, work, and benefit claiming, allowing them to claim Social Security while continuing to work. Comparing scheduled benefits, a deterministic expected-benefit reduction, and a stochastic solvency-risk environment, I find that recent high-solvency-risk conditions raise employment at ages 62–69 by 4.0 percentage points and increase the claimed-and-working share by 4.3 percentage points. Welfare losses are sizable but mostly reflect lower expected benefits rather than uncertainty itself: the total consumption-equivalent cost is about 4.2 percent of lifetime non-bequest consumption, while the pure-risk component is close to zero on average. Unresolved solvency risk is already a household-level economic shock, inducing older households to self-insure through work and claiming.

Work in Progress

[1] **Ambiguity Aversion and Fertility Decisions**

Abstract. This paper investigates how ambiguity aversion affects fertility decisions, considering the uncertainty surrounding the benefits of parenthood. We extend the Becker and Barro (1988) fertility model by incorporating ambiguity aversion to capture parents' decision-making process accurately. We assume that individuals care about their own and children's well-being (dynastic altruism) and face ambiguity about their children's future abilities (ambiguity aversion). Using a multiple priors utility framework, we model parents' preferences as maximizing their minimum expected utility of descendants, focusing on the worst-case scenario for their child's ability. Our findings suggest that more ambiguity-averse parents tend to have fewer children, as they emphasize the lowest possible outcome. This insight helps explain declining fertility rates and rising childlessness in developed countries, as individuals prioritize predictable outcomes over uncertain returns of parenthood.

Fellowships & Awards	Graduate Teaching Excellence Award (Top 10%), Iowa State University	2026
	Graduate Student Workshop Fellowship, Western Economic Association International	2026
	Summer Teaching Assistantship, Iowa State University	2025
	Most Engaging Presentation Award, EGSA, Iowa State University	2025
	Best Discussant Award, EGSA, Iowa State University	2025
	Research Travel Grant (\$750) × 4, Iowa State University	2023–2026
	Brain Korea 21 Plus Scholarship, Hanyang University	2020–2021
	Academic Scholarship HY-IN Graduate School Scholarship, Hanyang University	2020
	Academic Fellowship Korea Student Aid Foundation Fellowship	2019
	Graduation Award, Hanyang University	2019
Seminar & Conference	Econometric Society in Dynamic Structural Econometrics, University of Michigan [†]	2026
	101th Western Economic Association International [†]	2026
	North American Summer Meeting (NASM), Emory University	2026
	Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society (AMES), Vietnam (Accepted, but cancelled)	2026
	Workshop on AI and Machine Learning for Economists, Iowa State University	2025
	Southern Economic Association, Washington D.C	2025
	19th Economics Graduate Student Conference, Washington University in St. Louis	2024
	Midwest Macro Meetings, Purdue University	2024
	Macro Reading Group, Iowa State University	2024
	Midwest Economic Association, Chicago	2023
	[†] Scheduled.	
Academic Experience	Sole Instructor	Iowa State University
	ECON 1020: Principles of Macroeconomics (<i>Eval: 4.36/5.0</i>)	Summer, 2025
	Recitation Instructor – Graduate	Iowa State University
	ECON 6040: Advanced Macroeconomics Analysis (Ph.D. Core, <i>Eval: 5.0/5.0</i>)	2024S, 2025S, 2026S
	ECON 6020: Macroeconomic Analysis (Ph.D. Core, <i>Eval: 5.0/5.0</i>)	2025F
	ECON 6030: Advanced Microeconomics – Game Theory (Ph.D. Core, <i>Eval: 4.67/5.0</i>)	2023S
	ECON 5710: Intermediate Econometrics (Masters, <i>Eval: 4.5/5.0</i>)	2026S
	Teaching Assistant/Lab Instructor – Undergraduate	Iowa State University
	ECON 3710: Introduction to Econometrics (<i>Eval: 4.29/5.0</i>)	2021
	ECON 3020: Intermediate Macroeconomics (<i>Eval: 5.0/5.0</i>)	2025
	ECON 1020: Principles of Macroeconomics	2022, 2023, 2024, 2025
	ECON 1010: Principles of Microeconomics	2021, 2023, 2024
Academic Service	Discussions	
	“Urbanicity and Fertility: Evidence from Refugees to Canada”,	
	– Midwest Economics Association Meetings, Chicago	2024
	Guest Lecture	
	ECON3270 (Economics of Discrimination)	
	– Quantity-Quality Trade-off of Gary Becker’s Model	2025
	Other Service	
	Economic Help Room Services for the Undergraduates	2021, 2023

References

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